

Cognizant Leave Policy

****Effective Date:** January 1, 2026**

****Applicability:** All Full-Time Employees in India**

1. Overview

Cognizant is committed to providing its employees with a healthy work-life balance. We recognize that employees need time off to rest, recuperate, manage personal emergencies, and celebrate important life events. This comprehensive leave policy is designed to offer flexibility while ensuring that business commitments and client deliverables are met consistently. Eligibility for the various types of leave generally commences from the employee's date of joining, though specific accrual rules and usage criteria apply to different leave categories. The philosophy emphasizes mutual trust, where employees are expected to plan their time off responsibly and communicate effectively with their supervisors.

2. Types of Leave with Details

Casual Leave (CL)

- ****Quantum:**** 7 days per calendar year.
- ****Carry Forward:**** Casual leaves cannot be carried forward to the next calendar year. Unused CL lapses on December 31st.
- ****Usage:**** Can be availed for a maximum of 3 consecutive days.
- ****Approval:**** Requires prior approval from the manager for planned leave. For unplanned situations, the employee must inform the manager at the earliest possible time.

Sick Leave (SL)

- ****Quantum:**** 7 days per calendar year.
- ****Carry Forward:**** Unused sick leave can be carried forward to a maximum of 30 days.
- ****Usage:**** Can be used for the employee's own illness or to care for an immediate family member who is sick.

- ****Documentation:**** A registered medical practitioner's certificate is required if SL is availed for 3 or more consecutive days.

Privilege / Earned Leave (PL/EL)

- ****Quantum:**** 15 days per year, earned at a rate of 1.25 days per month of active service.
- ****Carry Forward:**** Can be carried forward to a maximum accumulation of 45 days.
- ****Encashment:**** Accumulated PL is encashable at the time of separation (resignation, retirement, or termination).
- ****Usage:**** Requires a minimum of 15 days advance notice for planned leave to ensure seamless project delivery.

Maternity Leave

- ****Quantum:**** 26 weeks of paid leave for the first two surviving children (as per the Maternity Benefit Act). For the third child onwards, the entitlement is 12 weeks.
- ****Eligibility:**** Applicable to female employees who have completed at least 80 days of continuous service with Cognizant in the 12 months immediately preceding the expected date of delivery.
- ****Usage:**** Covers both prenatal (up to 8 weeks before delivery) and postnatal periods.

Paternity Leave

- ****Quantum:**** 5 working days of paid leave.
- ****Usage:**** Must be availed within 1 month (30 days) of the child's birth. Applicable for up to two surviving children.

Bereavement Leave

- ****Quantum:**** 5 days for the demise of an immediate family member (spouse, child, parent, or parent-in-law). 3 days for extended family (grandparent, sibling).
- ****Usage:**** Should be taken consecutively and typically immediately following the event.

Marriage Leave

- ****Quantum:**** 3 days of paid leave.
- ****Usage:**** A one-time benefit provided for the employee's own marriage.

Compensatory Off (Comp-Off)

- ****Quantum:**** Earned for working on designated holidays or weekend rest days.
- ****Usage:**** Must be availed within 30 days from the date it was earned.
- ****Approval:**** Requires prior approval from the manager to work on the holiday/weekend and subsequent approval to avail the comp-off.

Loss of Pay (LOP)

- ****Usage:**** When an employee has exhausted all available leave balances and needs to take time off, they may be placed on Loss of Pay.
- ****Impact:**** LOP impacts the monthly salary proportionally (deducted based on the per-day rate). It also negatively impacts the calculation of variable pay (bonus) and certain benefits accrual.

3. Leave Application Process

All leaves must be applied for and approved through the ****iConnect portal****, which is accessible via the Cognizant intranet or the mobile application.

- ****Workflow:**** The employee submits a leave request in iConnect -> The request is routed to the reporting manager for review -> Once approved by the manager, it reflects in the HR leave system.
- ****Advance Notice:**** As specified above, PL requires 15 days notice. CL requires at least 1 day advance notice for planned leaves.
- ****Emergency Leave:**** In case of sudden illness or emergency (using SL or emergency CL), the employee must inform the manager via phone or email before the start of their shift. They should apply for the leave in iConnect immediately upon returning to work.

4. Leave Encashment

Leave encashment is applicable only for Privilege/Earned Leave (PL/EL) and is typically processed at the time of an employee's separation from the company.

- **Calculation Formula:** $(\text{Basic Salary} / 26) \times \text{Number of accumulated PL days}$.
- **Tax Implications:** Leave encashment is subject to income tax as per the prevailing Income Tax Act provisions. There are certain exemptions available up to specified limits as declared by the government, which will be calculated by the payroll team during full and final settlement.

5. Public Holidays

Cognizant provides approximately 10-12 public/national holidays per calendar year.

- **List Variability:** The exact list of holidays varies by office location (state/city) to align with regional festivals and observances, in addition to national holidays (Republic Day, Independence Day, Gandhi Jayanti).
- **Publication:** The holiday calendar for the upcoming year is published by HR in January and is available on the iConnect portal. Employees aligned to specific client locations or geographies (e.g., US, UK) may follow the client holiday calendar as advised by their project manager.

6. Work From Home (WFH) Policy

Cognizant currently operates on a hybrid working model.

- **Frequency:** The number of WFH days per week varies by project, client requirements, and specific business unit policies. Generally, employees are expected to be in the office 2-3 days a week.
- **Requirements:** Employees working from home must have a secure, high-speed internet connection and must use the Cognizant VPN for all official work to ensure data security.
- **Approval:** WFH schedules require manager approval to ensure adequate team coverage in the office.

7. Leave During Probation

- ****Eligibility:**** New joiners on probation are eligible to avail Casual Leave (CL) and Sick Leave (SL) from Day 1 of their employment, prorated based on their date of joining.

- ****PL Accrual:**** Privilege Leave (PL) accrual starts from the date of joining. However, PL can only be availed after the successful confirmation of probation.

8. Sandwich Leave Rule

The "Sandwich Rule" applies in certain leave scenarios, particularly when unauthorized absences or LOP is involved.

- ****Explanation:**** If an employee takes an unapproved leave on a Friday and a Monday, the intervening weekend (Saturday and Sunday) or public holidays will also be counted as leave (and potentially Loss of Pay).

- ****Example:**** An employee is absent without approval on Friday. They are also absent without approval on Monday. The leaves for Friday, Saturday, Sunday, and Monday (total 4 days) will be marked as LOP. Note: This rule is strictly applied to unapproved leaves to maintain discipline.

9. Attendance and Compliance

- ****Timesheet Submission:**** All employees must submit their weekly timesheets via the ****TimeMachine**** portal by Friday EOD. Accurate timesheet submission is crucial for client billing and compliance.

- ****Biometric Attendance:**** For office days, biometric attendance or ID card swiping is mandatory for entry and exit to track in-office presence.

- ****Consequences of Unauthorized Absence:**** Continuous unauthorized absence for more than 3 consecutive days may be treated as absconding, leading to disciplinary action up to and including termination of employment.

10. FAQs (Frequently Asked Questions)

****Q1: Can I club Casual Leave and Privilege Leave together?****

A1: No, Casual Leave (CL) and Privilege Leave (PL) cannot be clubbed together in a single leave application.

****Q2: What happens to my Earned Leaves at the end of the year?****

A2: Earned Leaves (PL) can be carried forward to the next year, up to a maximum limit of 45 days. Any leaves beyond 45 days will lapse.

****Q3: Is the medical certificate mandatory for a 2-day sick leave?****

A3: No, a medical certificate is only mandatory if the sick leave is for 3 or more consecutive days.

****Q4: Can I avail Paternity Leave in multiple phases?****

A4: No, the 5 days of paternity leave must be taken consecutively within one month of the child's birth.

****Q5: Who should I contact if my leave balance in iConnect seems incorrect?****

A5: You should raise a ticket in the HR Helpdesk portal under the 'Leave & Attendance' category.

****Q6: Does Comp-Off expire?****

A6: Yes, a Compensatory Off must be availed within 30 days of the date it was earned, otherwise it expires.

****Q7: Can I take half-day leaves?****

A7: Yes, half-day leaves can be applied for Casual Leave (CL) and Sick Leave (SL). Privilege Leave (PL) must be applied for full days.

****Q8: What is the notice period for PL if I want to take a 2-week vacation?****

A8: You must apply at least 15 days in advance for any planned Privilege Leave to allow for resource planning.

****Q9: If a public holiday falls during my Privilege Leave, is it counted as a leave day?****

A9: No, public holidays falling within an approved PL period are not deducted from your leave balance.

****Q10: Can Maternity Leave be extended?****

A10: The standard paid maternity leave is 26 weeks. Any extension required for medical reasons must be supported by medical documentation and can be taken as sick leave or loss of pay, subject to HR and manager approval.